



STUDY GUIDE FOR



CRISIS

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LETTER FROM THE EXECUTIVE BOARD

Dear Delegates,

Welcome to the Crisis Committee at UMTMUN 5.0.

The agenda before you is not an abstract policy debate. It is one of the most examined and most consequential events of the last century, and the decisions taken in its immediate aftermath continue to shape the world you live in today — including, very directly, the region you are sitting in as you read this.

This study guide is meant as a starting point, not a substitute for your own research. It will give you the historical grounding, the sequence of events, the positions of the actors involved, and the central questions this committee must confront. What it will not give you is a set of correct answers. There are none. The people who faced this crisis in 2001 were working with fragmentary intelligence, enormous public pressure, and no precedent to fall back on. You will be doing the same.

We expect delegates to come prepared with more than a surface-level understanding of what happened. Know your character. Know what they knew and when they knew it. Know what constraints they were operating under. A delegate who understands the pressures on their assigned role will always outperform one who has simply memorised a timeline.

Read widely, question what you read, and be ready to defend positions that may be uncomfortable. That is the point of this exercise.

We look forward to seeing you in committee.

The Executive Board

Crisis Committee, UMTMUN 5.0



THE CRISIS COMMITTEE: AN OVERVIEW

A crisis committee moves faster than a conventional General Assembly committee and places far more weight on the individual delegate. Rather than working towards a single negotiated resolution over the course of a session, delegates respond continuously to new developments — crisis breaks — that change the situation on the ground and force rapid reassessment.

Each delegate represents a specific person, not a country in the abstract. That person has their own authority, their own resources, their own institutional loyalties, and often their own agenda that does not perfectly align with the committee as a whole. The tension this creates is deliberate.

FORMAT OF THIS COMMITTEE

This simulation runs as a Joint Cabinet Crisis. Multiple bodies operate in parallel, each with different mandates, different information, and different priorities. The United States National Security Council is making decisions under domestic political pressure. The intelligence agencies are trying to establish facts while defending their own pre-attack record. The United Nations Security Council is attempting to build a legal and diplomatic framework. NATO is invoking a collective defence clause for the first time in its history. Pakistan is being asked to reverse a decade of foreign policy in a matter of days.

These bodies must communicate with each other, but they will not always trust each other, and they will not always share what they know. Managing that gap is part of the challenge.

TIMELINE OF THE SIMULATION

This committee operates within real history. Delegates are not reimagining events in an alternative universe — they are working within the actual sequence of September 11, 2001 and the weeks that followed. The committee opens on the morning of the attacks and extends through the decisions that culminated in Operation Enduring Freedom.



UNDERSTANDING THE AGENDA

Before entering committee, delegates must be clear on what this agenda actually asks them to grapple with. The September 11 attacks are widely known as an event. They are far less well understood as a crisis of decision-making.

The attacks themselves lasted 102 minutes. The decisions made in response to them shaped the following two decades. This committee is concerned primarily with the second part — with what should be done, by whom, under what authority, and at what cost.

WHY THIS AGENDA MATTERS FOR A CRISIS COMMITTEE

Very few historical events compress so many hard questions into so short a window. Within hours, decision-makers had to determine whether an attack of this scale constituted an act of war or a criminal act, whether existing legal frameworks were adequate, how much civil liberty could be sacrificed for security, and whether military force against a state that had not itself attacked the United States could be justified.

None of these questions had settled answers in 2001, and several of them remain contested today. That uncertainty is what makes the agenda suitable for a crisis simulation — and what makes lazy preparation immediately obvious in committee.



THE SCOPE OF WHAT WAS AT STAKE

The attacks killed 2,977 people from more than 90 countries. They destroyed a landmark of global commerce, struck the headquarters of the world's most powerful military, and came within minutes of hitting either the Capitol or the White House. The economic damage ran into hundreds of billions of dollars. The New York Stock Exchange closed for four trading days, the longest shutdown since 1933.

But the deeper consequence was psychological and political. The assumption that the American homeland was structurally secure — an assumption that had held since 1941 — collapsed in a single morning. Every decision taken afterwards was made under the shadow of that collapse and the fear that another attack was imminent.

THE REGIONAL DIMENSION

For delegates in Pakistan, this agenda carries a particular weight. Pakistan had been one of only three countries to formally recognise the Taliban government in Afghanistan. Its intelligence services had deep and long-standing relationships with Afghan factions dating back to the Soviet-Afghan war of the 1980s, when Pakistan served as the primary conduit for American and Saudi support to the mujahideen.

After September 11, Pakistan was presented with a demand for near-total cooperation: intelligence sharing, airspace access, logistical support, and the severing of ties with the Taliban. The decision to comply reshaped Pakistan's internal politics, its security environment, and its relationship with both Washington and Kabul for the next twenty years. Delegates should understand that the choices debated in this committee were not distant abstractions for this region — they were determinative.

HISTORICAL BACKGROUND

THE ORIGINS OF AL-QAEDA

The organisation responsible for the attacks did not appear suddenly in 2001. Its roots lie in the Soviet-Afghan war of 1979 to 1989, when tens of thousands of foreign volunteers travelled to Afghanistan and neighbouring Pakistan to join the resistance against Soviet occupation. Among them was Osama bin Laden, the son of a wealthy Saudi construction family, who used his personal fortune and organisational ability to establish support networks for these fighters. When the Soviets withdrew in 1989, bin Laden and a group of associates formed al-Qaeda — literally "the base" — as a vehicle for continuing armed struggle beyond Afghanistan. The organisation's grievances shifted towards the United States over the following years, driven in particular by the stationing of American troops in Saudi Arabia during and after the 1991 Gulf War. Expelled from Saudi Arabia and later from Sudan, bin Laden returned to Afghanistan in 1996, where the newly ascendant Taliban regime provided him with sanctuary. From there, he issued a formal declaration of war against the United States and began planning operations of increasing ambition.

ESCALATION BEFORE 2001

Al-Qaeda's capability grew steadily through the late 1990s. In August 1998, simultaneous truck bombs destroyed the US embassies in Nairobi and Dar es Salaam, killing more than 200 people, the overwhelming majority of them African civilians. The United States responded with cruise missile strikes against suspected training camps in Afghanistan and a pharmaceutical plant in Sudan — strikes that killed few operatives and drew criticism for their limited effect. In October 2000, a small boat packed with explosives struck the destroyer USS Cole in the port of Aden, killing 17 American sailors. The attack demonstrated that al-Qaeda could strike military targets, adapt its methods, and operate across multiple theatres. Each of these attacks provoked investigation, condemnation, and a limited response. None produced a fundamental reassessment of the threat.



THE INTELLIGENCE PICTURE

The most difficult question in the history of this period is what the United States government knew before the attacks, and why that knowledge did not translate into prevention.

The 9/11 Commission, established by Congress in 2002 to investigate the attacks, concluded that the failure was primarily one of imagination, policy, capability, and management rather than a lack of raw information. Signals existed. Two of the eventual hijackers were known to the CIA as al-Qaeda associates and had entered the United States. An FBI field agent in Phoenix had raised concerns about individuals with extremist connections enrolling at American flight schools. In Minneapolis, another suspect was arrested weeks before the attacks after arousing suspicion during flight training.

On 6 August 2001, President Bush received a Presidential Daily Brief carrying the title "Bin Ladin Determined To Strike in US." The document noted al-Qaeda's intent and referenced the possibility of hijackings, but contained no specific target, date, or method.

The information existed in fragments, distributed across agencies that were structurally discouraged from sharing it with one another. This institutional separation — the so-called "wall" between intelligence and law enforcement — became one of the central findings of the subsequent investigation and one of the principal justifications for the reforms that followed.

TIMELINE OF EVENTS

Delegates are expected to be thoroughly familiar with this sequence before the committee convenes. All times given are Eastern Daylight Time.

BEFORE THE ATTACKS

1979-1989: The Soviet-Afghan war draws foreign volunteers to the region. Osama bin Laden establishes support networks for incoming fighters, operating largely from Pakistan.

1988-1989: Al-Qaeda is formed as the Soviet withdrawal approaches, with the aim of continuing armed struggle beyond Afghanistan.

1996: Bin Laden returns to Afghanistan after being expelled from Sudan and issues a declaration of war against the United States. The Taliban, having taken Kabul, provide sanctuary.

August 1998: Simultaneous bombings destroy the US embassies in Nairobi, Kenya and Dar es Salaam, Tanzania. Over 200 people are killed. The United States responds with cruise missile strikes on targets in Afghanistan and Sudan.

October 2000: A suicide boat attack on the USS Cole in Aden, Yemen kills 17 American sailors and wounds 39.

6 August 2001: President Bush receives the Presidential Daily Brief titled "Bin Ladin Determined To Strike in US." No specific target, date, or method is identified.

11 SEPTEMBER 2001

7:59 AM: American Airlines Flight 11 departs Boston Logan International Airport for Los Angeles. Across the morning, nineteen hijackers board four transcontinental flights, each carrying heavy fuel loads.

8:46 AM: Flight 11 strikes the North Tower of the World Trade Center between the 93rd and 99th floors. All 92 people aboard are killed. Initial reporting treats the impact as a possible accident.

9:03 AM: United Airlines Flight 175 strikes the South Tower between the 77th and 85th floors, killing all 65 aboard. The impact is broadcast live. Any remaining ambiguity ends. President Bush, visiting an elementary school in Sarasota, Florida, is informed by his chief of staff that the country is under attack.

9:37 AM: American Airlines Flight 77 strikes the western face of the Pentagon, killing all 64 people aboard and 125 military and civilian personnel inside the building.

9:42 AM: The Federal Aviation Administration orders a nationwide ground stop — the first in American history. Every civilian aircraft in US airspace is ordered to land at the nearest available airport. More than 4,500 flights are brought down.

9:59 AM: The South Tower collapses fifty-six minutes after impact. Hundreds of emergency responders who had entered the building are killed.

10:03 AM: United Airlines Flight 93 crashes into a field near Shanksville, Pennsylvania. Passengers, informed of the other attacks by telephone, had attempted to retake the aircraft. Investigators concluded the intended target was either the Capitol or the White House.

10:28 AM: The North Tower collapses. The total death toll from the attacks reaches 2,977 victims, including 343 New York City firefighters and 71 law enforcement officers.

8:30 PM: President Bush addresses the nation, stating that the United States will make no distinction between the terrorists who committed the attacks and those who harbour them.



THE IMMEDIATE AFTERMATH

12 September 2001: The UN Security Council unanimously adopts Resolution 1368, condemning the attacks and recognising the right of individual and collective self-defence. On the same evening, less than twenty-four hours after the attacks, NATO allies invoke the principle of Article 5 for the first time in the alliance's history.

14 September 2001: Congress passes the Authorization for Use of Military Force, granting the President broad authority to use force against those responsible for the attacks. President Bush visits the site in Lower Manhattan and addresses rescue workers.

17 September 2001: President Bush authorises the CIA to conduct operations in Afghanistan against al-Qaeda and the Taliban.

20 September 2001: President Bush addresses a joint session of Congress and issues an ultimatum to the Taliban: surrender al-Qaeda's leadership, close the training camps, and grant access for verification — or share their fate.

28 September 2001: The Security Council adopts Resolution 1373 under Chapter VII of the UN Charter, imposing binding counter-terrorism obligations on all member states, including the suppression of terrorist financing.

2 October 2001: Having been briefed on the results of the investigation, the North Atlantic Council formally determines that the attacks fall within the scope of Article 5.

7 October 2001: The United States and the United Kingdom begin Operation Enduring Freedom with airstrikes against Taliban and al-Qaeda targets in Afghanistan.

KEY ISSUES BEFORE THE COMMITTEE

The following issues form the substantive core of debate in this committee. Delegates should arrive with considered positions on each of them.

I. ATTRIBUTION AND THE STANDARD OF PROOF

Before any response can be justified, responsibility must be established. But intelligence assessment is not the same as legal proof, and the standard applied has enormous consequences.

How certain must a government be before it uses military force against another state? Does a high-confidence intelligence assessment suffice, or is a public evidentiary case required? Who is entitled to see the evidence — allies, the Security Council, the general public? And what happens if the assessment proves partly wrong after force has already been used?

2. WAR OR CRIME?

This is the foundational legal question of the entire crisis, and the answer determines everything downstream.

If the attacks are treated as a criminal act, the response runs through investigation, extradition, prosecution, and the ordinary machinery of criminal justice. If they are treated as an act of war, the response runs through the law of armed conflict — which permits killing, detention without trial, and the use of force against territory.

Al-Qaeda was not a state. It held no territory in its own name, commanded no recognised army, and answered to no government. Existing international law was built around conflicts between states. Applying it to a non-state actor operating from the territory of a state that did not itself order the attack raised questions the framework was never designed to answer.

3. THE QUESTION OF STATE RESPONSIBILITY

The Taliban did not plan or execute the attacks. It did provide sanctuary to the organisation that did, and it refused to surrender that organisation's leadership when asked.

Does harbouring an organisation make a state legally responsible for that organisation's acts? At what point does tolerance become complicity? And if a government is deemed responsible, what may lawfully be done to it — targeted strikes, regime removal, occupation?

4. SELF-DEFENCE AND ITS LIMITS

Article 51 of the UN Charter preserves the inherent right of self-defence following an armed attack. Security Council Resolution 1368 explicitly recognised this right in the context of the September 11 attacks.

But self-defence against whom, for how long, and to what end? An attack that has already occurred cannot be prevented. If the justification shifts from responding to what happened towards preventing what might happen next, the doctrine expands considerably — and the question of where it stops becomes urgent.

5. SECURITY AND CIVIL LIBERTIES

Governments under attack face immediate pressure to expand surveillance, detention, and investigative powers. The measures adopted after September 11 — expanded electronic surveillance, indefinite detention of non-citizens, enhanced interrogation practices — were justified as necessary responses to an unprecedented threat.

Where is the line? Emergency powers are notoriously difficult to withdraw once granted. Should such measures carry automatic expiry dates? What independent oversight is required? And what is lost, in the longer term, if a society defends itself by narrowing its own freedoms?

6. COALITION-BUILDING AND REGIONAL COOPERATION

No military campaign in Afghanistan was possible without regional cooperation, and the most essential partner was Pakistan — a state that had until that week been one of the Taliban's principal international backers. The demands placed on Islamabad were substantial, and the domestic risks of compliance were severe. What can reasonably be asked of a partner state whose own stability may be threatened by cooperation? What should be offered in return? And what happens to the relationship when the immediate crisis passes?

7. PREVENTING THE NEXT ATTACK

Retaliation addresses what has already happened. Prevention addresses what has not yet happened, and it is the harder problem. Intelligence reform, aviation security, border controls, financial tracking, and international information-sharing all featured in the response. Each carries costs — financial, diplomatic, and in terms of individual liberty. Which measures actually reduce risk, and which merely provide the appearance of action?

THE CABINET: CHARACTER PROFILES

The following profiles describe the individuals represented in this committee. Delegates should treat these as a foundation for their own research, not as a complete brief. Understanding what your character knew, what they were responsible for, and what constrained them is essential to performing the role credibly.

UNITED STATES NATIONAL SECURITY COUNCIL

PRESIDENT GEORGE W. BUSH

Forty-third President of the United States, in office for less than eight months when the attacks occurred. His campaign and early presidency had focused on domestic priorities — tax policy and education reform — with foreign policy occupying a secondary position.

On the morning of 11 September he was at an elementary school in Sarasota, Florida. He was informed of the second impact by White House Chief of Staff Andrew Card and spent much of the day airborne aboard Air Force One, moving between secure locations before returning to Washington that evening.

As Commander in Chief he holds ultimate authority over the military response. His decisions in the following days established the framework of what became the War on Terror. Delegates in this role must weigh military options against diplomatic ones, manage a nation in shock, maintain international support, and do so with limited prior foreign-policy experience.

VICE PRESIDENT RICHARD "DICK" CHENEY

One of the most experienced figures in the administration, having previously served as White House Chief of Staff under President Ford, as a Congressman from Wyoming, and as Secretary of Defense during the 1991 Gulf War.

During the attacks he was moved by Secret Service agents to the Presidential Emergency Operations Center beneath the White House, from where he participated in decisions including the authorisation to engage hijacked civilian aircraft. With the President airborne and communications intermittent, Cheney was functionally at the centre of the government's response for much of the day.

He consistently argued for a broad and forceful response, holding that the threat could not be addressed through law enforcement alone. Delegates in this role should understand both the depth of his institutional experience and the expansive view of executive authority he brought to the crisis.

NATIONAL SECURITY ADVISOR CONDOLLEEZZA RICE

A Soviet specialist by academic training, Rice served as Provost of Stanford University before joining the administration. As National Security Advisor she was responsible for coordinating policy across the Departments of State and Defense, the CIA, and the military — a role that carries little independent authority but considerable influence over what reaches the President.

She received the 6 August Presidential Daily Brief and later gave public testimony on the pre-attack intelligence picture. In committee, this role sits at the centre of information flow: managing competing departmental recommendations, ensuring the President is presented with genuine options rather than a single predetermined path, and mediating between the diplomatic and military camps.



SECRETARY OF DEFENSE DONALD RUMSFELD

Serving his second term as Secretary of Defense, having previously held the post under President Ford in the 1970s. He was in the Pentagon when Flight 77 struck the building and assisted with casualty evacuation before returning to the National Military Command Center.

He had entered the post committed to transforming the American military towards lighter, faster, technology-intensive forces — a doctrine the Afghanistan campaign would test directly. He raised the possibility of a broader response extending beyond Afghanistan in the earliest days after the attacks.

Delegates in this role control the military instrument: force posture, deployment timelines, target selection, and the practical question of what is achievable in a landlocked country with no American bases nearby.

SECRETARY OF STATE COLIN POWELL

A retired four-star general and former Chairman of the Joint Chiefs of Staff, Powell had overseen the 1991 Gulf War before entering civilian office. His military background gave him unusual credibility when arguing for restraint.

He was strongly associated with the doctrine bearing his name — that military force should be used only with clear objectives, overwhelming resources, broad public support, and a defined exit. Within the administration he was the leading advocate for coalition-building, for working through the United Nations, and for pursuing diplomatic options before military ones.

This role carries responsibility for assembling international support, securing overflight and basing rights, and managing relationships with allies whose cooperation is essential but not guaranteed.



DIRECTOR OF CENTRAL INTELLIGENCE GEORGE TENET

Appointed under President Clinton and retained by President Bush, Tenet had warned repeatedly about al-Qaeda in the years before the attacks and had characterised the threat level during the summer of 2001 in urgent terms.

The CIA delivered the earliest assessment attributing the attacks to al-Qaeda and, within days, presented a plan for a covert campaign in Afghanistan combining agency paramilitary officers, special operations forces, Northern Alliance militias, and American airpower. Delegates in this role occupy a difficult position: they are simultaneously the principal source of intelligence driving the response and the head of an agency facing serious questions about what it failed to prevent.

UNITED STATES INTELLIGENCE AND LAW ENFORCEMENT

FBI DIRECTOR ROBERT MUELLER

Sworn in on 4 September 2001 — one week before the attacks. A former Marine officer and career federal prosecutor, he inherited an agency structured for criminal investigation rather than terrorism prevention. The FBI launched the largest investigation in its history to identify the hijackers, trace their movements and financing, and determine whether further attacks were planned. Mueller subsequently oversaw a fundamental reorientation of the Bureau towards intelligence and prevention.

In committee, this role must balance the demands of a criminal investigation — which requires preserving evidence and respecting legal process — against intense pressure for immediate operational results.

NSA DIRECTOR MICHAEL HAYDEN

An Air Force general heading the National Security Agency, responsible for signals intelligence and communications interception. The agency had collected material referencing the possibility of a major attack but had not identified the plot.

After the attacks, the NSA's authorities expanded substantially, including surveillance programmes that later became the subject of considerable public controversy. Delegates in this role must weigh the operational value of expanded collection against its legal and constitutional implications.



UNITED NATIONS

SECRETARY-GENERAL KOFI ANNAN

Serving his second term as Secretary-General, Annan was awarded the Nobel Peace Prize in October 2001 alongside the United Nations itself. His position required balancing genuine solidarity with the United States against the institutional obligation to ensure that any response remained within the framework of international law and the UN Charter. This role carries moral authority but no enforcement power — influence must be exercised through persuasion and legitimacy rather than compulsion.

PERMANENT MEMBERS OF THE SECURITY COUNCIL

The five permanent members — the United States, United Kingdom, France, Russia, and China — each hold a veto and each approached the crisis from a distinct position.

- United States — the victim of the attacks, seeking international endorsement for its response while retaining freedom of action.
- United Kingdom — the closest ally, committed to participating directly in military operations from the outset.
- France — supportive of solidarity measures but insistent that any use of force be properly grounded in the Charter.
- Russia — offering cooperation and intelligence on the region, while drawing parallels between al-Qaeda and the insurgency it faced in Chechnya.
- China — condemning the attacks and supporting counter-terrorism in principle, while remaining wary of any precedent legitimising intervention in a sovereign state



NATO

SECRETARY GENERAL LORD GEORGE ROBERTSON

A former British Defence Secretary, Robertson presided over the North Atlantic Council when it invoked the principle of Article 5 on the evening of 12 September — the only time in the alliance's history that its collective defence clause has been triggered.

The invocation was initially conditional, pending determination that the attack had been directed from abroad; that determination was formally made on 2 October. Robertson then coordinated a package of support measures for the United States, including intelligence sharing, blanket overflight clearances, port and airfield access, and the deployment of NATO airborne early warning aircraft to patrol American airspace.

Delegates in this role must translate a statement of solidarity into concrete commitments from nineteen member states with varying levels of enthusiasm and differing domestic political constraints.



PAKISTAN

PRESIDENT PERVEZ MUSHARRAF

Chief of Army Staff since 1998 and head of state following the military takeover of October 1999, Musharraf faced the most difficult set of choices of any actor in this crisis.

Pakistan was one of only three states to have formally recognised the Taliban government, and its intelligence establishment maintained relationships with Afghan factions dating back to the Soviet-Afghan war. Within days of the attacks, Pakistan was presented with a demand for comprehensive cooperation: intelligence sharing, airspace and logistical access, border control, and the termination of support for the Taliban. Compliance meant reversing a decade of strategic policy, accepting significant domestic political risk, and facing opposition from religious parties and elements within his own security establishment. Refusal meant international isolation, likely sanctions, and the prospect of a hostile military campaign on Pakistan's western border conducted without its consent.

He chose cooperation. Delegates in this role should understand that the decision was neither simple nor cost-free, and that its consequences for Pakistan extended far beyond the immediate crisis.



RULES OF PROCEDURE AND CRISIS DOCUMENTS

STRUCTURE OF COMMITTEE

The committee operates through two channels. The Frontroom hosts official proceedings, managed by the Chair and Assistant Chairs, who facilitate caucuses, guide the drafting and merging of directives, and conduct voting. The Backroom is directed by the Crisis Director, who issues crisis breaks, adjudicates private directives, and steers the simulation. Assistant Chairs pass information between the two in the form of crisis notes.

CRISIS DOCUMENTS

Three document types are used in this committee

DIRECTIVES

Directives are concise action documents. They require no perambulatory clauses and are not subject to a question-and-answer session. When a directive is motioned, the Chair selects two delegates to speak in favour and two against before the committee votes.

PUBLIC DIRECTIVES

Public directives reflect the official, collective position of the committee. They are introduced openly and debated in the frontroom.



EXAMPLE:

Public Directive: Immediate Closure of United States Airspace and Activation of Continuity of Government Protocols

Committee: [Name of Committee]

Delegate: [Your Delegation / Character Name]

Preamble:

In light of the ongoing coordinated attack against the United States, the confirmed use of commercial aircraft as weapons, and the continuing threat to civilian populations and government infrastructure, this committee holds that immediate action is required to secure the civilian population, protect the continuity of constitutional government, and establish control over national airspace. The following measures are to take effect without delay:

Operative Clauses:

- **Immediate Airspace Closure:** The Federal Aviation Administration is directed to order all civilian aircraft in United States airspace to land at the nearest available airport. All inbound international flights are to be diverted. No civilian departures are authorised until the scope of the threat has been assessed.
- **Continuity of Government:** The Vice President and designated members of the line of succession are to be relocated to secure facilities. Under no circumstances are the President and Vice President to be co-located until the threat is contained.
- **Air Defence Posture:** Combat air patrols are to be established over Washington DC and New York City. Rules of engagement regarding non-compliant civilian aircraft are to be issued through the National Military Command Center and reported to this committee.
- **Inter-Agency Coordination:** A joint operations channel is to be established linking the FAA, NORAD, the Department of Defense, and the intelligence community, to prevent the communication failures evident in the first hour of this attack.

Conclusion:

This directive is submitted on the understanding that the protection of civilian life and the continuity of lawful government are the first obligations of this body.

We urge unanimous support.

Signature: _____



PRIVATE DIRECTIVES

Private directives are covert actions submitted directly to the Crisis Backroom. They advance a delegate's individual or institutional agenda outside official proceedings, and the Backroom may approve or reject them. An approved action may later surface as a public crisis break.

Note the tension this creates in a joint cabinet. A directive submitted by one faction may be actively concealed from another faction sitting in the same room. Example:

Personal Directive: Covert Deployment of Field Officers to the Afghanistan–Pakistan Border Region

To: Crisis Backroom

From: George Tenet, Director of Central Intelligence

Date: 11 September 2001

Given the assessment attributing today's attacks to al-Qaeda, and given that the organisation's senior leadership is believed to be located in or moving through the Afghanistan–Pakistan border region, I request authorisation to activate existing agency assets and deploy a paramilitary team to establish real-time collection on leadership movement. This must occur before any public statement of American intent alerts the target.

Objectives:

- Establish contact with existing agency assets and Northern Alliance commanders to map current al-Qaeda locations and movement patterns.
- Identify the financial, logistical, and communications networks sustaining the organisation in the region.

Operational Constraints:

- Communications to run on encrypted satellite channels outside standard diplomatic traffic.
- No contact with Pakistani intelligence services until the President has spoken directly with President Musharraf and cooperation has been formally secured. Until that point this operation remains compartmented from the Pakistani government.

The window for this collection is narrow. Every day of delay degrades the intelligence picture. I request immediate authorisation.

George Tenet, Director of Central Intelligence



PRESS RELEASE

Press releases are public communications used to inform a wider audience, shape the narrative, and signal a faction's position without committing to operational action. In this crisis they carry unusual weight: managing public panic, reassuring allies, and signalling intent to adversaries were all conducted substantially through public statements. Example:

PRESS RELEASE

United States Government Confirms Coordinated Terrorist Attack; Emergency Measures in Effect

Date: 11 September 2001 | For Immediate Release

The United States government confirms that the events of this morning in New York City and Arlington, Virginia were deliberate, coordinated acts of terrorism. This is not a matter of speculation, and it will be treated accordingly. Emergency services are operating at both sites. National airspace has been closed and all civilian aircraft ordered to land. The continuity of government has been secured. Federal institutions are functioning and will continue to function. An investigation is underway. We will not speculate publicly on responsibility until that investigation has produced findings we can stand behind. When it does, those findings will be acted upon — and those who planned these attacks, along with those who sheltered and financed them, will be held accountable. We ask the public to remain calm and to rely on official sources for information. We ask the international community to join us in condemning these attacks and in the work of preventing others like them. This country has faced serious challenges before and has met them. It will meet this one.

For Further Information:

Contact: [Office of the Press Secretary]

Phone: [Contact Number]

Email: [Contact Email]



COMMUNIQUÉS

Communiqués are formal messages addressed to a specific entity rather than to the public at large. They are used for ultimatums, formal demands, declarations, or requests for mediation. They are less frequent than the other document types, but at the right moment they can alter the course of the simulation decisively. Example:

COMMUNIQUÉ

From: The Government of the United States of America

To: The Leadership of the Islamic Emirate of Afghanistan

Date: 20 September 2001

The Government of the United States holds that the organisation responsible for the attacks of 11 September operates from Afghan territory, with the knowledge and protection of the authorities in Kabul. This communiqué sets out what is required.

Deliver to United States authorities the leadership of al-Qaeda sheltering in your territory. Close every training camp associated with the organisation. Provide access for verification that these camps have in fact been closed. Release any foreign nationals unlawfully detained.

These are not terms for negotiation. They are not subject to partial compliance or to delay. If they are met, the United States is prepared to discuss the future relationship between our governments. If they are not met, the United States will act to achieve these objectives by other means, and will hold your government responsible for the consequences of that choice.

The decision rests with you. The time available to make it is limited.

The Government of the United States of America

TOOLS FOR DISCUSSION

MODERATED CAUCUS

Because crisis committees are small, delegates commonly speak more than once within a single moderated caucus. This is where the substantive arguments happen — over the standard of proof for attribution, the legal character of the response, the scope of emergency powers, and the terms of regional cooperation.

UNMODERATED CAUCUS

Used less frequently than in General Assembly simulations, and for a different purpose: merging similar directives into a single stronger document before a vote. In a joint cabinet, this is also where factions negotiate privately across bodies.

ROUND ROBIN

Every delegate speaks in turn within a fixed time limit, usually one minute, with no one skipped. Most useful at the opening of a session and immediately following a crisis break, when the committee needs a rapid reading of where every faction stands.

CRISIS BREAKS

Updates issued by the Crisis Director that alter the situation and demand immediate response. In this simulation they may include confirmation of the fourth aircraft, an intelligence assessment naming those responsible, reports of a further threat, a communication from a foreign government, or a public statement from al-Qaeda. Delegates should expect their positions to be overtaken by events and should be prepared to adjust quickly.



QARMA

QUESTIONS A RESOLUTION MUST ANSWER

The following questions define what this committee is expected to resolve. Any directive, resolution, or set of measures produced by this body should engage substantively with them. Delegates should prepare positions on each before committee begins.

1. What standard of evidence must be satisfied before responsibility for the attacks is formally attributed, and to whom must that evidence be disclosed — the Security Council, allied governments, or the public?
2. Should the attacks be treated as an act of war or as a criminal act, and what legal framework consequently governs the response — the law of armed conflict, or domestic and international criminal law?
3. Under what circumstances does providing sanctuary to a non-state armed group render a state legally responsible for that group's actions, and what measures may lawfully be taken against such a state?
4. How should the right of self-defence under Article 51 of the UN Charter be interpreted and bounded when the attacking party is a non-state actor, and what limits apply to its duration, geographic scope, and objectives?
5. What expansion of surveillance, detention, and investigative powers is justified in response to this threat, what oversight must accompany it, and what mechanisms should govern its eventual withdrawal?
6. What can reasonably be required of regional partner states whose cooperation is essential to any response, what should be offered in return, and how should the domestic risks borne by those partners be accounted for?
7. What structural reforms to intelligence coordination, aviation security, border control, and terrorist financing should be adopted to reduce the likelihood of a comparable attack, and how should their effectiveness be measured?



FURTHER READING AND RESEARCH RESOURCES

Delegates are expected to research beyond this guide. The following sources are official government publications, primary documents from international organisations, and archived institutional records.

Preference should always be given to primary sources and official records over secondary commentary.

A note on research: the September 11 attacks attract a very large volume of unreliable and deliberately misleading material online. Delegates should confine their research to government archives, official documents of international organisations, and established news organisations with editorial accountability. Material that cannot be traced to an identifiable and credible institution should not be relied upon in committee.

PRIMARY AND OFFICIAL RESOURCES

1. The 9/11 Commission Report (National Commission on Terrorist Attacks Upon the United States, 2004)

The definitive official investigation into the attacks. Commissioned by Congress and signed into law by the President, the 585-page report covers the origins of al-Qaeda, the planning of the plot, the intelligence and policy failures that preceded it, the response on the day itself, and detailed recommendations for reform. This is the single most important source for this agenda and delegates should read at minimum the Executive Summary and Chapters 1 and 8.

<https://www.9-11commission.gov/report/911Report.pdf>

2. 9/11 Commission Records — United States National Archives

The complete archived records of the Commission, held by the National Archives and Records Administration. Includes staff monographs, staff statements, hearing transcripts and video, witness lists, and commissioner biographies. Useful for delegates researching specific characters or specific institutional failures in detail.

<https://www.archives.gov/research/9-11>

3. UN Security Council Resolution 1373 (2001) — United Nations

Adopted unanimously on 28 September 2001 under Chapter VII of the UN Charter, and therefore binding on all member states. Imposes obligations on states regarding the suppression of terrorist financing, the criminalisation of support for terrorism, and international cooperation on information sharing. Essential reading for delegates working on the legal and financial dimensions of the agenda.

https://www.unodc.org/pdf/crime/terrorism/res_1373_english.pdf

4. Collective Defence and Article 5 — North Atlantic Treaty Organization

NATO's official account of the only invocation of Article 5 in the alliance's history. Sets out the sequence from the conditional invocation on 12 September through the formal determination of 2 October, and details the eight support measures subsequently agreed. Directly relevant to delegates representing NATO and allied positions.

<https://www.nato.int/en/what-we-do/introduction-to-nato/collective-defence-and-article-5>

5. Address to a Joint Session of Congress, 20 September 2001 — George W. Bush White House Archives

The full official transcript of the speech in which President Bush set out the American response and issued the ultimatum to the Taliban. A primary document of considerable importance for understanding how the administration framed the crisis publicly and what it committed itself to.

<https://georgewbush-whitehouse.archives.gov/news/releases/2001/09/print/text/20010920-9.html>



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6. Public Papers of the Presidents — United States Government Publishing Office (govinfo)

The official published record of presidential statements, addresses, and executive actions, maintained by the Government Publishing Office. Provides authenticated versions of the documents delegates will need when citing American policy positions from this period.

<https://www.govinfo.gov/content/pkg/WCPD-2001-09-24/pdf/WCPD-2001-09-24-Pg1347.pdf>

7. National September 11 Memorial & Museum — Digital Exhibitions and Learning Resources

The institutional archive of the memorial museum, including documented timelines, oral histories, primary artefacts, and curated material on the international response. Particularly useful for understanding the human dimension of the attacks and the response of the international community.

<https://www.911memorial.org/learn/resources>